check the physical stamina, determination, courage, team spirit and cooperativeness of each of the candidates. In the IO test, we were made to go through several sets of obstacles, each carrying different marks based on their level of difficulty. The test had to be completed in the given time constraint, and I was able to finish seven out of the ten obstacles. I had planned to tackle the obstacles in decreasing order of their marks, and the three obstacles that I had left out carried the lowest marks, so I ended up doing fine.

The GOR was more of a fun run, with obstacles like a wall, a net of ropes, tyres and so on, all of which we had to manoeuvre. The candidates were divided into groups of ten, and then two groups at a time were made to race simultaneously. For the PGT, there was a set of obstacles on the ground, and members of a group were made to cross each obstacle according to a set of rules. Also, while crossing these obstacles, they were given a load to carry. Material that would help them cross was provided by the GTO, such as a *balli* (wooden log), a plank and a rope with which to tie the balli or the plank. The difficulty level increased with each obstacle, which is how the task gets its name. Our group was able to complete the task well in time. The HGT was similar to the PGT, and the only difference was that the group was further divided into two more sets. We ended up doing just fine in this task too.

On the evening of the fourth day of our SSB interview, Sqn Ldr Yadav had given us the liberty to go outside the centre and enjoy ourselves. The first place Hema and I headed to was the majestic Mysore Palace. We had planned to spend our evening there and then grab a snack before going back to the centre. Sqn Ldr Yadav had asked everyone to be back before eight.

‘Are you up for some filter coffee? Mysore is famous for it,’ Hema asked as I finished reading the tourist info board.

‘Do you know a place?’ I asked.

‘Appa had told me about a place that serves the best dosa and filter coffee in Mysore,’ an excited Hema said.

After a final glance at the grandeur of the palace, we started walking away from it. Hema had been to Mysore many times before, so she knew